

Google has a dedicated Webmaster Guidelines support page, where it lists all the ways an SEO can illicitly increase page rank. Here are some of the most common don'ts. The punishments for these are harsh, and it is best avoided.

1) Keyword Stuffing

Ever encountered a link that said something like “The best books by best bookstore cheap home delivery dictionary”? If you see a link like this on your browser, would you ever consider clicking it? No. Even the most basic link analysing algorithms will detect this as spam, and might easily blacklist it. Instead, it is far more valuable to earn a single good link from a source that doesn't consider you a spammer.

2) Don't over-link

Over-linking is possibly the most popular way to spam, and is a tempting way to manipulate links so that it can (try to) fool the search engine's use of link popularity to determine ranking. There are many ways of doing this, including reciprocating links – where sites create links that lead to one another, in order to increase each other's popularity. Link farming is another way of doing this. This is where scores of low-value websites are made so that it increases the link's ranking.

Spam is constantly evolving and software engineers continue to battle it, updating algorithms to include a stricter and stricter norm, which means that if you are caught using such 'black hat' practices to improve the visibility of your website, chances are that it will eventually be taken down.

3) Don't buy links to promote your website

This practice stems from the previous one, as it involves contacting websites that are willing to place your link in exchange for money. These are usually part of bigger networks of link buying and selling, similar to a link farm. Google in particular, has taken very harsh action against such practices. Take for example, the time when Google banned Google Japan for ELEVEN MONTHS because it was found that they were buying links. JC Penny was banned for 3 months. Bing doesn't have any penalty against buying links, but they frown upon it.

4) Don't hide text

Text can be hidden in several ways on your webpage. Some of the easier ways is to change the colour of the text to the colour of the background,